alive. He described the USA and Canada based organisation's role as the fountainhead of Punjab's insurgency. 'My close friendship with Chatar was risky but I did not see any other way to execute covert operations to neutralise the senior echelons of the Khalistan movement,' Mathur told me.

His special access to Chatar landed him another blind date—Dr Gurmeet Singh Aulakh. A research scientist turned self-proclaimed Khalistani leader, he had become the face of the Khalistan movement and a prominent figure in the USA, lobbying hard with American lawmakers for a separate state for Sikhs in India. With considerable influence at the Capitol, Aulakh and his associates had declared an independent Khalistan in late 1987 and his efforts in subsequent years were focused on getting the status of a sovereign state for Punjab as a new Sikh nation. According to Mathur, unlike other Khalistan leaders in the USA who were involved in terror attacks, Aulakh's primary focus was propaganda against the Indian government. While militant outfits disintegrated in Punjab, Aulakh launched a massive war against the Indian government, accusing it of Sikh genocide. Indian diplomats and spies followed his activities in Washington DC with growing alarm and voluminous reports were sent to New Delhi. Mathur said he was the first R&AW spy to gain access to Aulakh and he confronted the Khalistan leader with documentary evidence of his involvement with US officials to create political instability back home.

'He was soft spoken but very gritty. I thought he would be apologetic after seeing the documents, but I was wrong. Aulakh had utter contempt for India and was deeply in love with the USA. He had no intention of stopping his organisation's activities. He was aggressive and we decided to keep a watch